

Portugal Itinerary

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Porto: The Wine City & Unexpected Lessons

We arrived in Porto on a night bus, groggy and backpacked, at 4 a.m.—way too early to check into our guesthouse. The lady had made it clear: no luggage drop before 10 a.m., and our GuruWalk tour started at 10:30. We did the mental math—guesthouse > wash up > tour point—and quickly realised it was a stretch. So, we did what true travellers do: got ready in the train station washroom.

That washroom—with its glass doors and half-exposed sink areas—felt like a social experiment. I've never dressed for a city tour in such cinematic fashion. It felt weirdly empowering. Messy hair, no concealer, strangers walking by—and suddenly I realised most girls around me did know their makeup basics. I didn't. And yet, there I was, tying up laces and pretending I was part of a movie montage about a girl figuring things out. I wasn't glamorous. I was present. And that counts for a lot.

We reached the guesthouse by 9 a.m., and the Russian host (not fluent in English but warm in her own way) allowed us to drop off our luggage. Her reception desk was a gallery of world souvenirs—little globes, postcards, trinkets from far corners. I liked her already.

The weather, in hindsight, was a blessing. A little windy, a little sunny, with the occasional drizzle. Considering what came later in the trip, this was premium.

Day 1 Of Wine, Wandering & Wonder

We reached the meeting point by 10 a.m., mostly retracing the **entire walking tour path** just in search of breakfast. We eventually gave up, munched on protein bars, and began the tour with cautious expectations—especially because, let's be honest, **Xavier had completely ruined us** for basic tour guides.

Our guide was sweet, but jhabreile baal wale ladke just don't work for me. ■ Yes, I'm biased. No, I won't apologize.

But Porto itself? Gorgeous. They call it the **City of Wine**—famous for **Port wine**, though we debated whether it was worth trying since we aren't really wine people. Still, the architecture? Classic European drama meets riverside charm. Romans and Moors left behind impressive legacies—sewage systems, cathedrals, and curious street arrangements that whisper stories.

There was even a grand **McDonald's housed in a historic building**—a mashup of gold trimmed ceilings and fast food counters that felt oddly poetic.

Day 1 When Cities Talk Back

As always, I skipped the food details (reserving that for a proper foodie chapter), but what I won't skip are the **conversations** that followed. Our guide shared stories of economic challenges, and how more and more locals were leaving their own country. It hit me—hard.

In India, there's this unspoken myth: *that baahar sab kuch better hota h*. But you travel a little and realize—**every country has its beauty, its burden, and its balance**. Everyone struggles with something. Everywhere is someone's escape, and someone else's reality.

And that thought kept echoing as I walked those narrow cobbled lanes.

We also learned that **J.K. Rowling** lived in Porto for a while—and they say the city inspired Hogwarts. You could see it, honestly. From the fountains to the gothic bookstores, everything here felt a little

more enchanted once that rumor got into your head.

Day 2

Beach, Blunders & Nata Redemption

Post-tour, we took a **1.5-hour bus ride** to the beach, hoping for a laid-back moment. I was so exhausted, I slept through most of the scenic views—and thanks to **Tikku**, we missed our stop. Classic.

Cue another round of walking in drizzle and cold, but eventually we reached Porto's beach. My **first beach of the trip**. European beach culture is so different. Calm. Quiet. Movie-like. No loud music. Just people, scattered like thoughts, staring into the waves.

We returned to the city and went for dinner at a **vegan buffet**, which was underwhelming at best. So I turned to Google for dessert therapy—and stumbled upon **Pastel de Nata**, a flaky, eggy custard tart that **absolutely made up for everything**. We devoured two, guilt-free. Sometimes a dessert is so good, it deserves a clean conscience.

Back at the guesthouse, the host had kindly placed our bags in our room. We slipped into our beds, muscles sore, skin chilly, hearts a little fuller. The drizzle tapped at the windows like punctuation to the paragraph of our day.

Must-Visit Places in Porto

If you ever find yourself in Porto, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Ribeira District:** Colorful riverside buildings.
- **Livraria Lello:** Majestic historic library facade.
- **Clérigos Tower:** Panoramic views of the city.
- **Dom Luís I Bridge:** The famous iron arch bridge.
- **São Bento Railway Station:** Captivating azulejo tile murals.
- **Palácio da Bolsa:** The breathtaking Arab Room.
- **Church of São Francisco:** Ornate Baroque interiors.
- **Port Wine Cellars:** Local cellars at Vila Nova de Gaia.

Lisbon & Sintra: Steep Streets, Fado & a Bowl of Daal Chawal

We had our bus to **Lisboa** at 1 p.m., reaching the city by 4. But before saying goodbye to Porto, there was one thing left to do: **Pastel de Nata**—one last glorious bite. It was raining, we had our backpacks, but the craving was stronger than comfort. So, we detoured, walked into that famous shop *with all our luggage*, and stood there savoring it one last time, paired with coffee. As I write this, I can almost taste it. Europe has me hopelessly in love—with its desserts, its quiet indulgences, its unapologetic charm.

We clicked a photo near the "**I Love Porto**" sign, smiled at the drizzle, and boarded our bus—hearts full, sugar high, and clothes a little soggy.

Day 1

Lisboa Welcomes: Cold, Rainy, and Steep

By 4:30 p.m., we were checking into **Norte Guest House** in Lisbon. The plan? Hit at least one **Hop-On Hop-Off bus route** today, then cover the other two and a walking tour tomorrow. But Lisboa had its own agenda.

Steep roads. Cold wind. Rain that didn't pour—but whispered constantly. Shoes wet. Socks soggy. No sign of sun. It felt less like sightseeing and more like survival cardio. Lisbon isn't gentle—but she's honest.

At 5 p.m., we rushed to the bus stop, only to be told our online ticket wasn't enough — we'd need to exchange it for a physical one. The catch? The counter was **2.5 km away** and closed at 6. We *sprinted*. Drenched and breathless, we reached at **6:05 p.m.** Missed it by *five minutes*. The last bus had left. Of course.

Day 1

The Universe, and a Bowl of Daal Chawal

A little defeated but still hungry for something warm, we wandered the nearby lanes. That's when we realized: we were staying right by the famous **Santa Justa Lift**. Beautiful to look at, but ridiculously overpriced. We gave it a pass—and let our legs suffer the slanted climbs instead.

By now, I was drenched, drained, and craving only one thing: **hot daal chawal**. My comfort food. My hug in a bowl. And somehow—*miraculously*—the cosy vegan buffet we chose had exactly that. Imagine, in the chilly corners of a European capital, a plate of daal chawal finding its way to me. The Universe must love comfort food too.

We returned to our hostel with full hearts and heavier bellies. We mapped out plans for tomorrow—Pink Street, a brunch spot, and the remaining bus routes. A long day awaits. But tonight, Lisboa tucked us in gently. With rice, lentils, and rain.

Day 2

Stories in Stone and Cinnamon

We woke up at 9 a.m., still groggy, still wrapped in the light drizzle that seems to love Lisbon as much as its tiled walls do. In the rush, we forgot to check with the hostel for umbrellas and just left—classic us.

At **11 a.m.**, we met our walking tour guide—a true Lisboaeta. Born, raised, and fluent in the city's contradictions. She led us through **four distinct neighborhoods**, tracing stories across **blue-tiled façades**, the soulful **Alfama district**, churches that survived brutal earthquakes, and streets narrow enough to barely breathe in.

We learned about **Fado music**, felt its sorrow in the air even without a song. Took **Ginja shots in chocolate cups**—a local trick to warm the chest and chase away coughs. Saw the **world's oldest operating bookstore**, walked down the **narrowest street in the world**, and caught charming details: how in Alfama, people **tile their homes with their own photos and bios**, so you know exactly who's behind each door.

And cinnamon. Oh, cinnamon. It's Portugal's unofficial love language—sprinkled on everything from coffee to custard tarts. And honestly? I'm a convert.

Day 2

Buses, Bookstores, and a Quiet Regret

After the tour, we boarded our **Hop-On Hop-Off bus**—finally using the ticket we'd fought so hard for the day before. The moment we sat down, Lisbon turned up the drama: **heavy rain**, rhythmic and relentless. We saw the city through misted windows, rooftops swimming in silver.

We completed **all three routes**, ticked off every color-coded loop, then set out—again on foot—to visit the iconic **oldest bookstore**. Harshit nudged me to buy something, but I didn't. Maybe it felt too rushed, maybe I was tired, maybe I just couldn't decide. But I regret it now. One of those *small regrets that linger quietly*. I've promised myself—I'll go back one day, and when I do, I'll pick out a book without overthinking.

Day 3

Sintra: Slopes, Palaces & a Slice of Cake Before Goodbye

Our last day in Lisbon came with a choice: laze through the city or hustle to Sintra. If you know me, you already know which path we picked.

We woke up early, packed our bags, and checked out of Norte Guest House—except there was no one at the reception. So in peak Bollywood-thriller fashion, we left a handwritten note, slid it under the glass window, and tucked our backpacks behind a sofa, hoping for the best. (They were safe. Lisbon isn't out to get you.)

We caught the train to Sintra, just an hour away but a whole different world. The moment we arrived, Lisbon's slopes felt like gentle suggestions. Sintra? It's a stairmaster disguised as a fairytale town.

There are plenty of palaces to explore here, but we aimed for the iconic Pena Palace, perched at the top like a storybook fortress. We smartly booked a private drop till the peak, saving our knees the uphill battle, and decided to walk down to the station post visit.

Rain greeted us again, along with sharp winds that tried to turn our umbrella into modern art. Pena Palace was whimsical and haunting under grey skies—moodier than the postcards, and perhaps even more beautiful for it.

We started our descent—steep, winding, and scenic with forests peeking through mist and occasional giggles from the path. Harshit, true to form, slipped again, and this time a lady tying her shoelaces froze mid-lace to ask if he was okay, still bent down, still unfazed. A scene so random, I can't unsee it.

Day 3

And the Skies Cried With Us

Back in Lisbon, we were starving and exhausted—but mostly craving warmth. We stopped by a nearby **café**, and as we ate, we watched **streets flood under pouring rain**. Within an hour, the roads dried up like nothing had happened. No chaos, no honking. Just quiet restoration. That kind of resilience—that's something Europe wears well.

We grabbed our bags from behind the sofa (still there!) and made our way to the **FlixBus for Faro**. The rain followed us all the way, and the bus WiFi didn't work (of course). But something about that moment—dark clouds, wet windowpanes, winding roads—it was the perfect setting to reflect. There wasn't much to do but **watch the journey play on loop** in my head.

We reached **Faro at 8 p.m.**, carrying the weight of our soaked shoes, full bellies, and the bittersweet ache of a day well spent.

Must-Visit Places in Lisbon & Sintra

If you ever find yourself in Lisboa, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Alfama District:** The heart of Fado music culture.
- **Belém Tower:** Iconic riverside Manueline fortress.
- **Jerónimos Monastery:** UNESCO World Heritage marvel.
- **Pink Street (Rua Nova do Carvalho):** Colorful art district.
- **Santa Justa Lift:** Gothic iron elevator with city views.
- **Pena Palace, Sintra:** Fairytale hilltop palace.
- **Praça do Comércio:** Grand riverside square.
- **Oldest Bookstore (Livraria Bertrand):** World record holder.

Faro & Carvoeiro: Sun, Cliffs & the Estômbar Station Confusion

After all the rain in Porto and Lisbon, Faro finally gave us something we'd almost forgotten existed: **sunshine**. We arrived at 8 p.m., tired, carrying soggy memories and damp shoes, and checked into our stay. The clock was ticking—just **two days** to squeeze the Algarve for everything it was worth.

We'd decided not to keep Faro city as our base but instead **hop around the region**—Carvoeiro for the cliffs, Estômbar for the chaos, and Faro itself for the old town magic. With limited time and endless ambition, we planned big. Let the Algarve saga begin.

Day 1

Faro Old Town: Bougainvillea & Cobblestone Calm

Morning one in Faro started slow and golden. We explored the **Faro Old Town (Cidade Velha)**, a walled medieval enclave that sits quietly beside the lagoon. Narrow streets lined with whitewashed houses and the odd burst of bougainvillea. A church that survived the 1755 earthquake. Cats that have clearly decided this town belongs to them.

There's something almost *unhurried* about Faro—unlike the busy tourist trails of Lisbon or the crowd of Porto's bridges. It's a city you can breathe in. And after days of racing through rainy streets, this was exactly what we needed.

We wandered the **Arco da Vila**, a beautiful 19th-century gate into the old town, storks nesting on the towers above. We explored the **Sé Cathedral**, climbed its bell tower for panoramic views over the **Ria Formosa lagoon**—a beautiful nature reserve of flat waters, salt marshes, and sky.

Day 1

The Estômbar Confusion: A Lesson in Portuguese Train Stations

We had planned to take a train to **Carvoeiro** via **Estômbar station**, the nearest train stop to the cliffs. Easy, we thought. Booked the tickets. Boarded the train. Felt very organized.

What we hadn't fully internalized was that *Estômbar station* and *Carvoeiro* are not walking distance apart. They're connected by a local bus that runs on its own schedule, in its own universe, with zero regard for tourist itineraries. We arrived at Estômbar station to find ourselves in a **tiny village**, with one road, one elderly man who shrugged cheerfully, and a bus timetable that hadn't been updated since the mid-2000s.

We stood there, luggage in hand, at what felt like the edge of Portugal, wondering if Google Maps had been drunk when it suggested this route. A local eventually pointed us toward the bus stop. The bus came. We made it. But those forty-five minutes at Estômbar station—priceless.

Day 2

Carvoeiro: Where the Algarve Actually Lives

Carvoeiro is one of those places that makes you wonder why you ever went anywhere else. A small fishing village turned resort town, with terracotta rooftops tumbling toward dramatic golden cliffs that meet the Atlantic in small, secretive coves.

We walked the **Boardwalk at Algar Seco**—a naturally formed rock formation carved by the sea. Arches, grottos, pools filled by the tide, and the sound of waves echoing through hollow stone. It was

dramatic and utterly serene at the same time. We stood at the edge, wind pulling at our clothes, and understood why people buy a house here and never leave.

The main beach at Carvoeiro is small and sheltered, hemmed in by the ochre cliffs. We sat on the sand, had some ice cream (finally, European sun that warranted ice cream!), and felt the accumulated stress of jet-lagged rain-soaked city-hopping just quietly dissolve.

Day 2

Pedras Amarelas & Hidden Grottoes

We found a trail that wound along the clifftop—**Pedras Amarelas**—past cactus gardens, sea caves, and lookout points where the ocean stretched to infinity in three directions. Harshit, as expected, did not photograph me enough, and as expected, photographed dramatic cliff formations more than humans. Balance, we have not achieved.

The grottos here are accessible by kayak or small boat from the beach. We didn't book in advance (classic), so we watched others paddle into azure caves from our clifftop perch and made a silent promise to return. Carvoeiro is worth returning for. Full stop.

Day 2

Return to Faro: Sunset and Seafood

We navigated Estômbar in reverse—this time knowing which bus to catch—and made it back to Faro in the golden hour. The lagoon lit up in warm orange, the old town walls glowed, and we finally had fresh **Algarve seafood** for dinner. Grilled fish, simple and perfect, the kind that doesn't need dressing up.

The Algarve had been the reward at the end of a grey, rainy Portuguese chapter. And it delivered in full. Sometimes all you need after a week of European winter moods is a coastal region that's been hoarding the sunlight for you.

Must-Visit Places in Faro & Carvoeiro

- **Faro Old Town (Cidade Velha):** Walled medieval charm.
- **Sé Cathedral Bell Tower:** Panoramic lagoon views.
- **Ria Formosa Natural Park:** Serene coastal wetlands.
- **Arco da Vila:** 19th-century stork-nesting gate.
- **Algar Seco, Carvoeiro:** Dramatic sea-carved rocks.
- **Carvoeiro Beach:** Sheltered golden cove.
- **Pedras Amarelas Trail:** Clifftop coastal hiking path.
- **Kayaking the Grottos:** Sea cave exploration by boat.

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